

إعادة النظر في مفهوم الاغتراب: تحليل نقدي لكتابات كارل ماركس المبكرة

Alienation Revisited: A Critical Analysis of Karl Marx's Early Writings

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الملخص:

تحاول الدراسة الحالية تقصي مفهوم الاغتراب عند كارل ماركس، باعتباره موضوعاً محورياً في الفلسفة والعلوم الاجتماعية، نظراً لصلته الوثيقة بالواقع الإنساني في ظل المنظومة الرأسمالية، مستندة إلى تحليل نقدي للكشف عن الكيفية التي تعمل من خلالها الرأسمالية على تغريب الإنسان عن نتاج عمله، وعن عملية الإنتاج نفسها، وعن إنسانيته، وعن الآخرين من بني جلدته. يركز هذا التحليل على العوامل التي تعزز الاغتراب، مثل الملكية الخاصة والاقتصاد السياسي وتقسيم العمل، كما تم استعراض الحل الذي اقترحه ماركس، والمتمثل في إلغاء الملكية الخاصة وإقامة مجتمع شيوعي كوسيلة لتجاوز الاغتراب. وعلاوة على ذلك، فقد قدمت هذه الدراسة نقداً لنظرية ماركس يتمثل في تركيزها على الطبقة العاملة في شرح مفهوم الاغتراب وإغفالها أبعاداً أخرى لهذا المفهوم، مثل الجوانب الوجودية أو الروحية. والجدير بالذكر أنه رغم كل المآخذ على نظريته، تخلصت الدراسة إلى أن نظرية ماركس -التي مرّ أكثر من نصف قرن على صياغتها- لا تزال تمثل إطاراً نظرياً مهماً لفهم الاغتراب والمعاناة الإنسانية في المجتمعات الرأسمالية المعاصرة.

الكلمات المفتاحية: الاغتراب، كارل ماركس، الرأسمالية، الملكية الخاصة، الطبقة العاملة.

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Abstract:

This study explores Karl Marx's concept of alienation, a key theme in philosophy and social sciences due to its relevance to human conditions under capitalism. It critically analyzes how capitalist systems cause workers to become alienated—from the products they create, the production process, their own humanity, and fellow humans. The analysis focuses on factors that reinforce alienation, such as private property, political economy, and the division of labor. The study also examines Marx's proposed solution: the abolition of private property and the establishment of a communist society as a means to overcome alienation. Additionally, it addresses key criticisms of Marx's theory, including its focus on the working class to the exclusion of other dimensions of alienation, such as existential or spiritual aspects. Despite these critiques, the study concludes that Marx's theory remains a compelling framework for understanding alienation and human suffering in contemporary capitalist societies.

Keywords: Alienation, Karl Marx, Capitalism, Private Property, The Working Class.

Introduction:

Research into concepts related to the human being is a matter of interest across the humanities. These concepts have been—and still—the subject of considerable controversy, given that the humanities are, by their very nature, relativistic in their approach to their subjects and do not include any absolute judgments. Furthermore, these concepts, like individuals and nations, do not arise from a void or fall from the sky; rather, they are formed at the bottom of human society and crystallize from the great suffering that humans experience in dealing with countless problems throughout their lives (Rajab, 1988, p. 8). Among these concepts is the concept of alienation, which is one of the most prominent concepts that has captured the attention of thinkers in both the humanities and social sciences. Given its cognitive importance, on the one hand, and its widespread prevalence in the current era, on the other, alienation constitutes a major suffering for the people of this era, affecting numerous social segments. Moreover, the

consequences and repercussions of this era—especially with technological progress—
increase and deepen the alienation of the human from oneself, one's society, and one's
human existence.

As a result, the concept of alienation remains controversial in academia and has been
addressed from numerous perspectives, and has received various interpretations.
However, there has been no consensus on this concept, nor has a unified vision been
reached. This can be attributed to the cognitive and semantic intensity of this concept, as
it is not easy to enumerate all of its meanings and connotations. If it is interpreted
legally, it means the transfer of ownership of something to another person and in this
sense, it includes what can be called the objectification of human relations, the
transformation of living human beings into inanimate objects or subjects (Khalifa, 2003,
p. 24). In a religious context, it relates to the separation of man from God and to sin and
the commission of transgressions (Hamad, 2005, p. 64). Meanwhile, the psychosocial
context of the concept refers to the mental disturbances that occur to the individual, and
the alienation one might feel in the world as well as the coldness or iniquity in his
relationship with others (Rajab, 1988, p. 32).

Given this diversity of contexts within which the concept of alienation is embedded, and
the current study's inability to fully encompass the various aspects through which it has
been studied, we chose to study this concept through the lens of an important German
sociologist and thinker, Karl Marx. The concept of alienation occupied a prominent
position in Marx's theories, and he is considered a pioneer of the conflict school in
sociology. Marx devoted numerous works to this subject, analyzing the economic
conditions of people under the capitalist system, which makes them suffer from
exploitation and alienation. The restriction to this thinker does not mean that this
concept was only addressed by him, rather, there are many sociologists who have
addressed it in different contexts. Choosing him specifically stems from an attempt to
reach a broader understanding of this concept and the way in which he addressed it to
identify the meanings presented by him.

Based on the above, it can be said that the current study attempts to answer a number of
questions as follow:

- What meanings does the concept of alienation carry?

- How was this concept manifested in the thought of Karl Marx?
- What pitfalls did Karl Marx fall into in his study of this concept?

Methodology:

The method of critical analysis was adopted to address Karl Marx's concept of alienation and analyze his propositions and delve deeper into the study of this epistemological problem. This approach is considered one of the most appropriate for the current study due to its main principles' in gaining broader knowledge about the research problem. Although this approach is one of the most popular approaches in theoretical studies, it relies on the researcher's subjective analysis, which can lead to fall in the trap of subjectivity. To mitigate the impact of this subjectivity that characterizes this type of approaches, we will rely mainly on objective matters in the writings of Karl Marx.

Conceptualization:

The concept of alienation is characterized by ambiguity and complexity, as it was mentioned earlier, due to the diversity in its connotations and meanings. The French philosopher Paul Ricoeur (1994) considered it a pathological concept as it suffers from the influence of “semantic overload.” This means it faces the danger of reaching a stage where it no longer means anything at all as a result of this overload. Moreover, Boudon and Bourricaud (1986) argued that alienation has a legal explanation (transfer or sale of property or rights), a psychological explanation (general intellectual weakness), a sociological explanation (dissolution of the bond between the individual and others), and a religious explanation (dissolution of the bond between the individual and the gods).

Most of the definitions of alienation—within the scope of this study—have focused on the social aspect, considering this concept limited to one image: separation from society only. Among these definitions is Al-Jawhari's definition in (1983), which considered it the state that completely controls the individuals, making them feel like stranger and distant from some aspects of their social reality. Borgatta and Montgomery (2000) defined it as the isolation of individuals from society and their separation from the activities, traditions, and connections that society provides. Vandenbos (2015) deemed alienation as the separation of the individuals from their social group, such as family,

workplace, local community, school, or church. Also, Theodorson and Theodorson (1980) defined it as a feeling of non-participation and detachment from society and its culture.

Other definitions emphasize the psychological aspect of alienation, including Maatouk's definition in (1998) as the loss of one's distinctive personality. However, there are other definitions that were not limited to the social or psychological aspects of alienation, but rather combine both aspects, such as Omar's definition in (2000), which considered it the exclusion or estrangement of individuals from themselves and from others. Some definitions went further, such as Statt's (1998) who defined a term that carries various social and psychological meanings, all of which refer to feelings of separation, disunity, and powerlessness, whether in relation to oneself, nature, others, wealth, or the means of production in society as a whole.

Al-Hajj (2000) defines it from a completely different perspective than the previous definitions where he saw it as the transformation of a person's characteristics and capabilities into something independent and controlling, and the transformation of some phenomena and relationships into something different from what they are in themselves.

From the above, it can be concluded that the concept of alienation—in light of the previous definitions—is a state of separation and isolation of the individuals from themselves, on the one hand, and from the surrounding society, on the other, and from all phenomena of the objective world, on the third. This leads them to be unable to deal with their internal and external world normally.

Dimensions of Alienation:

Many studies have discussed the dimensions of alienation and have differed in their classification. One of them was Seeman's (1995) study in which five dimensions were proposed:

Powerlessness: This is the expectation or probability that individuals carry, such that their own behavior cannot determine the occurrence of the outcomes or reinforcements they seek. Seeman asserts that powerlessness is not viewed from the perspective of objective social conditions, although these conditions may be relevant.

Meaninglessness: This is the state in which individuals are unclear about what they should believe, and where the minimum standards of clarity in their decision-making are not met.

Normlessness: This is derived from Durkheim's concept of anomie, and Seeman also refers to Merton's contributions to this dimension. It is defined as the state in which there is a strong expectation that socially unacceptable behaviors are required to achieve certain goals.

Isolation: Seeman believes that isolation is commonly used to refer to the role of the intellectual; Writers refer to their detachment from the norms of popular culture. Aliens—in the sense of isolation—are those individuals, such as the educated, who place low value on goals or beliefs that are usually highly valued in the given society.

Self-Estrangement: This is defined as the degree of dependence of a given behavior on anticipated future rewards or on rewards that lie outside the activity itself. This means that the alienated individuals are unable to connect with themselves, their life proceeds without purpose, and they live as a respondent only to what life will offer. This dimension was prominent in the writings of Erich Fromm (2009), and he dealt with it in a different way than Seeman, as he believed that when people separate from themselves, they got objectified. If you ask a person, 'Who are you?', they will answer, 'I am a factory owner,' or 'I am a clerical employee,' or 'I am a doctor,' or 'I am married,' or 'I am the father of two children,' and to a large extent their answer has the meaning that the answer of a speaking thing would have.

However, the classification of Dean (1961) was limited to three dimensions of alienation: *powerlessness*, *normlessness*, and *social isolation*. Their dimensions of powerlessness and normlessness are no different from those presented by Seeman, while they believes that social isolation can be perceived in Durkheim's concept of anomie, which includes a feeling of separation from the group or isolation from its norms. Russell Middleton (1963), divided the dimensions of alienation into: *powerlessness*, *meaninglessness*, *normlessness*, *cultural estrangement*, *social estrangement*, and *estrangement from work*. They did not offer different meanings for powerlessness, meaninglessness, and normlessness than the previous explanations. However, in their definition of cultural estrangement, they meant the unpalatability of

what is desired by people. Middleton chose this term to distinguish it from Seeman's traditional concept of "isolation." Social estrangement intersects with what Dean presented regarding social isolation. Middleton highlights Seeman's rejection of this dimension, deeming it meaningless. As for estrangement from work, which they means the lack of desire for the work the worker performs, despite being forced to do it to satisfy the needs and desires, Middleton considers this dimension an indicator of the dimension of self-estrangement, as stated in Seeman's classification.

Al-Nouri (1979) also points to six dimensions of alienation: separation, transition, objectivity, lack of power and authority, lack of meaning, and the disappearance of standards. The first three dimensions differ from what was previously presented in explanations, and the last three are consistent with what was presented about powerlessness, normlessness, and meaninglessness. Al-Nouri believes that the dimension of separation is used to describe the states that result from the inevitable cognitive separation of specific elements in reality and this meaning was prominent in the writings of the German philosopher Hegel. Nevertheless, they believes that alienation in the sense of transition is different from what preceded it, as it is linked to the process of relinquishing one of the contractual rights, and this meaning has been employed in English historical research. It refers to the denial and confiscation of a person's property rights, or the transfer of these rights from one person to another. Objectivity, on the other hand, refers to an aspect of alienation defined by an individual's awareness of the presence of others. Research indicates that this state is often accompanied by feelings of loneliness and isolation rather than tension and frustration.

Stages of Alienation:

According to Barakat (2006), alienation is a process that passes through three organically linked stages. These stages are as follows:

The First Stage: This stage concerns the individual's position within the social structure of society. This stage has two aspects. The first relates to the nature of the social, political, and economic structures in society. While the second relates to the individual's position within these structures, in terms of the extent to which they are deprived of participation in institutions and means of production, and the extent to

which they are able to uphold their rights and change their circumstances. Barakat believes that this stage is linked to sources of alienation, such as fragmentation and social disintegration, the crisis of civil society, the dominance of the patriarchal system over institutions, class exploitation, dependency on external factors, and the entrenched rituals of the past.

The second stage: This relates to the individuals' awareness of their marginal status in society. This status leads them to develop a sense of rejection of relationships with society and its institutions, and to reject and flee from the prevailing cultural systems at the first opportunity, rather than changing them.

The third stage: This relates to actual behavior and attempts to liberate oneself by seeking ways to break free from prevailing systems and conditions. An individual experiencing this type of alienation is forced to choose between one of three behavioral alternatives to escape and transcend it. These alternatives are:

A. Escape from and withdrawal from reality: In this alternative, the individuals may be unable to continue coexisting with society, its institutions, workplace, and surrounding relationships. They realize they lack the ability to change reality or refuse to submit to it, even superficially. As a result, they attempt to withdraw and escape from this reality, seeking other alternatives to free themselves from the alienation they are experiencing. This withdrawal often takes different forms depending on the surrounding circumstances on the one hand, and the availability of possibilities that might save them from their miserable reality, even if only formally, on the other. In the midst of these situations, some may consider emigration as the best possible solution. Others may remain in their communities, but they isolate themselves from public affairs and devote themselves to their private activities without caring about what is going on around them.

In addition to emigration and isolation, there are also other forms of withdrawal, such as distancing oneself from family relationships, disbelief in religion, and adopting sectarianism as an alternative—which, at its core, is a denial of religion and its spiritual values. They also indulge in delusions and indulgence in recreational activities that temporarily make the expatriate forget their suffering. Withdrawal is often criticized as embodying pessimism, despair, and a failure to deal with reality. However, for some, it remains an alternative to which they resort to deal with their reality.

B- Acceptance and Submission to Reality: Here, the individual pretends to accept reality publicly while implicitly rejecting it. This alternative provides a refuge for some due to their lack of ability to change so they rely mainly on patience and this alternative is usually accompanied by a sense of hope for imminent relief. Besides, it might manifest in compliments, concessions, flattery, bargaining, and other practices that may lead to harmony with society rather than rejection of it.

Submission, like withdrawal, often becomes a subject of criticism. A person's submission to what they implicitly rejects is a condition called “*cognitive dissonance*” in social psychology, which indicates that an individual is rarely able to reconcile two contradictory ideas or feelings about themselves without forming a motivation to resolve that by establishing some kind of balance. It often serves as an unconscious justification process due to the difficulty of coexisting with this type of contradiction. Hence, this alternative does not allow for overcoming alienation as much as it stabilizes it.

C- Individual Rebellion or Revolutionary Action: In this case, the individual may rebel instead of withdrawing and submitting, confronting society and its institutions and working to change the reality. However, this alternative must take a collective, not an individual, character within social movements seeking change in an attempt to escape alienation.

Karl Marx Concept of Alienation:

The young Marx explores the concept of alienation, elaborates on its manifestations and causative factors, and presents a specific vision for overcoming it as a concrete condition from which the worker suffers. In keeping with the broad outlines of the study, the concept of alienation according to Karl Marx will be analyzed by examining the conditions of workers under capitalism, as this helps clarify their view of alienation, its causative factors, and the vision Marx offered for overcoming it.

Conditions of Workers under the Capitalist System:

Marx examines the conditions of workers under the control of the capitalist system and the state of alienation they experience. Before examining the alienation of workers according to Marx, it is necessary to understand their conditions and the situations they

endure. This is useful in further clarifying the concept of alienation, on the one hand, and in view of the connection between their conditions and their alienation, on the other. The harsh conditions they experience represent an aspect that cannot be ignored when attempting to understand the reality of this alienation and the underlying reasons behind it. The worker—under the control of the capitalist system—suffers the most abhorrent types of exploitation. As society's wealth declines, the most affected are those who are unable to earn as much as the owner (Marx, 1974, p. 17). With the increase in the wealth, which can be a favorable circumstance for workers, competition increases among capitalists, demand for supply increases, and workers' wages also rise. However, this rise carries with it many risks for the worker, and forces them to sacrifice their time more to obtain what they want, and to perform slavish work in the service of money and its power, and to lose their freedom completely (Marx, 1974, p. 18). When society reaches its greatest degree of wealth, workers' wages decline and competition among workers for work increases, leading to wages falling to the subsistence level (Marx, 1974, p. 20). Hence, Marx clearly indicates that in the case of the decline of society - the worker's increasing misery; in the case of progress - misery with its complications; in the case of the full development of society - static misery (Marx, 1932, p. 5).

Workers, under capitalism, lose their humanity and are treated as a commodity rather than a human being, and their status is linked to market conditions. In conditions where supply exceeds demand, the workers are threatened with beggary or starvation, and their existence becomes equal to that of any other produced commodity and they will be fortunate enough if they find a customer. Moreover, the demand for workers in these conditions is determined by the whims of capitalists and the wealthy. During sudden market fluctuations, workers' wages are most affected compared to the profits of the capitalist or the rent of the landowners (Marx, 1947, p. 17). Although the fate of the workers is linked to the capitalist, they do not necessarily gain when the capitalist gains, but they necessarily lose with their loss (Marx, 1974, p. 17). This clearly illustrates the unfair condition of the workers. Marx points out that what the workers receive is the smallest and absolutely indispensable part of the product; that is, what is necessary only for their existence, not as a human being, but as workers, and for their reproduction; but not human reproduction, but for the reproduction of a slave class of workers (Marx, 1932, p. 5). In addition, the workers become poorer as their products increase, and they

descend to the level of commodities, becoming cheaper than these products. Since the value of the world of things is inversely proportional to the value of the human world, the increase in the value of things is inevitably matched by a decrease in the value of the human world (Marx, 1974, p. 69).

It is worth noting that the close connection between Marx life's suffering and his analysis of the conditions of the working class can be clearly discerned in their propositions. Their difficult life, punctuated by poverty, suffering, and debt, overshadowed their vision of the conditions of workers. Thus, he lived and experienced their ideas before writing about them. He believed that even the need for fresh air ceases for the worker, and human returns to living in the cave, which is now, moreover, contaminated with the same putrid plague that the city breathes. They no longer occupies except precariously, becoming for them a strange dwelling from which they can be taken away at any day—a place from which they can be evicted at any day if they does not pay. They must pay for this grave (Marx, 1974, p. 108). Marx experienced this situation when he lived in a house that was not fit for living and his life was filled with debt, and did not have the most basic human requirements.

After clarifying the conditions of workers analyzed by Marx under the control of the capitalist system, it is necessary to study the alienation of workers under the same system, how this concept manifests itself in light of his philosophy, and the foundations he relied on to explore its depths.

Manifestations of Alienation:

Alienation, according to Marx, means that humans no longer exercise themselves as an active force in the process of their understanding of the world, but rather that the world (nature, others, and themselves) remains alienated from them. This concept is, essentially, a passive and receptive experience of the world and of oneself, as if the self is in a state of separation from the object (Fromm, 1998, p. 63).

For Marx, alienation is expressed within the framework of work as it is the active connection between nature on the one hand and humanity on the other. This connection enables the creation of a new world and also allows humanity to create itself. Marx also believes that the alienation of work is at its highest levels in a capitalist society, and in

this society, workers are the most alienated (Fromm, 1998, pp. 66-68). Although Marx studied the alienation of workers, he emphasized that alienation is not only limited to workers, but rather that all people suffer from it. He points out that everything that appears in the worker as an activity of alienation, appears to the non-worker as a state of alienation (Marx, 1974, p. 80), but he did not study anything but the alienation of workers in their youth works. Additionally, Marx identifies four interconnected manifestations of alienation:

A. Alienation from the Product:

Marx believes that the conditions of exploitation experienced by the workers under capitalism pave the way for their alienation, which increases as they feel that the goods or products they produce become separate from them. They create the product and breathe life into it only to find it alien to them and encounter it as something independent, finding themselves unable to own it. Marx points out that this fact expresses only the object produced by labor—what is called the product of labor—faces them as something alien, as a power independent of the producer (Marx, 1923, p. 29).

Marx used Hegel's terminology in his study of the concept of alienation, particularly the concept of realization (Marx, 1923, p. 78), using it to mean the objectification of the product and its coming into existence. This objectification completes the workers' alienation within the scope of their work. When the product is created and objectified, it quickly becomes alienated from its creator. Thus, the product of labor is labor that has been embodied as an object and has become material; it is the objectification of labor. Under these economic conditions, this realization of labor appears as a loss of reality for the workers; objectification as loss of the object and enslavement to it, and possession as alienation (Marx, 1932, p. 29). In addition, the alienation of this product does not merely mean its position outside and independence from its producer. Rather, it reaches the point where the product becomes more powerful than the workers themselves, confronting them as an enemy after being created by them (Marx, 1974, p. 69).

Furthermore, the relationship between the workers and their product takes on a reversible character. The more the workers produce their products, the more powerful they become and the less able the workers are to own them, and they become controlled by them after having previously controlled them (Marx, 1974, p. 69). On the other hand,

the accumulation of labor provided by the workers to produce products leads to the ownership of the product and the means of the workers' activity being taken away from them and concentrated in the hands of the few who own; That is, in the hands of the capitalists (Marx, 1932, p. 4).

In his book "Capital", Marx explained the state to which products and commodities devolve into what he called the "fetishism¹ of commodity." He argues that capitalism transforms human relations into non-social, object-based relationships. Products and commodities come to dominate people's lives after they have been produced. They also resemble the religious ideas that humans produce and control, increasing their power to the point of worship (Marx, 1985, p. 108).

Since the workers' product is alien to them, the environment surrounding their work will also be alien to them, and the process of production will, for them, embody the state of alienation they experiences.

B. Alienation from the Process of Production:

Alienation from the process of production precedes alienation from the product, but Marx mentioned it in their manuscripts as a second aspect. However, the first aspect would not have occurred without the second aspect. How can the workers confront the product of their activity if they do not, in the process of production itself, alienate themselves from themselves? The product, after all, is nothing but the total of the productive activity. If the product of labor is the alienation, production itself must be an active alienation (Marx, 1974, p. 71).

Hence, alienation from the product is closely linked to alienation from the production process. Under these conditions, the workers' work is external to them and does not belong to them, their selves are excluded within the work, and the only emotions that dominate them are unhappiness and misery. Their physical and mental energies are

¹ Fetish: a natural or unnatural object, living or inanimate, believed to possess an unnatural power, or to be possessed by a spirit, which must therefore be appeased. Fetishism is a tendency to view divinity as a body or a natural force. However, in psychology, it takes on another meaning, which is the sexual attachment to parts of the body, clothing, or other objects that cause sexual arousal (Badawi, 1982, p. 159). However, Marx use of it means idolatry or paganism, and refers to a state in which the products of one's own hands, i.e., goods, control one, and in which these fetishistic products reach the stage of being worshipped by people.

constantly being destroyed, and where their work is not voluntary but forced. As a result, they have no choice but to be alienated from this environment and completely devoid of belonging to it (Marx, 1932, p. 30).

On the other hand, this aspect indicates that the workers' own activity becomes alien to them, alienated from their own, less able to control it, and transformed into pain and suffering for them. Since this activity is an integral part of the individual's life, alienation from it paves the way for alienation from the self (Marx, 1974, p. 72).

From the above, it can be said that the two aforementioned aspects of alienation necessarily lead to alienation from the species, which is the third aspect of alienation according to Marx.

C. Alienation from Species:

Alienation from species is the third aspect of alienation. In this aspect, Marx derives the concept of species-being from Feuerbach (Marx, 1932, p. 78), and uses it to explain the third aspect of alienation. The concept of species-being refers to the fact that humans possess free and conscious activity, which distinguishes them from animals and makes them species-beings (Marx, 1974, p. 73). In addition to the fact that humans live within the confines of nature and depend on its resources for survival, their relationship with it does not depend solely on this. Rather, nature represents for them—because the human is a species-being—the subject and material of their life activity, transforming it and reshaping it in various forms. The relationship between them is one of mutual influences and impact, as there is no human without nature, and no nature without human (Marx, 1974, p. 73).

According to Marx, work is the essence and nature of humans, not merely a means of satisfying needs. Human's species-specific essence is determined in light of work and production (Marx, 1932, p. 31). In addition, the subject of labor is the objectification of human's species-life as it multiplies themselves not only intellectually—as occurs in consciousness—but also in action—in reality—and hence contemplates themselves in the world of their creation. Thus, estranged labor, by its distance from humans strips them of their species-life and transforms their advantage over animals into its opposite; that is, their inorganic body—nature—is stripped away from them (Marx, 1974, p. 74).

In this estrangement, humans' relationship with nature is transformed into an instrumental relationship (Drysdale, 1969, p. 101). For humans, nature becomes merely a means of existence, as their relationship with it is limited to reliance on its resources, whereas their relationship with it was one of mutual influence and interaction. The degeneration of spontaneous and free activity into alienated labor makes humans' species-life a mere means for their physical existence. Thus, humans' species-consciousness is transformed through alienation into a way in which species-life becomes a means for them. Likewise, alienated labor transforms human's species-being into an existence which is alien to them and a means for their individual existence. It alienates humans from their body, just as it alienates their external nature and their spiritual, human side (Marx, 1932, p. 32).

Based on the interconnected relationship between alienation manifestations, alienation from the product, the production process, and the species will necessitate alienation from other people.

D. Human's Alienation from Other People:

A direct consequence of the fact that humans are alienated from the product of their labor, from their life activity, and from their species-being, is human's alienation from others. When humans confront themselves, they confront others. What applies to humans' relation to their labor, to the product of their labor, and to themselves, applies to humans' relation to others, to their labor, and to the object of their labor (Marx, 1932, p. 32).

Despite the close connection between the aspects of alienation, this aspect of alienation is particularly linked to alienation from the species (Drysdale, 1969, p. 102). Human's species nature is alienated from them means that the human is alienated from the other, just as each of them are alienated from human's essential nature and that man's relationship to themselves becomes objective and real for them through their relationship with the other humans (Marx, 1932, p. 32-33). On the other hand, this aspect of alienation, in which humans are separated from themselves and from others, occurs within a social environment and in the context of social interaction with others.

Humans' alienation is realized and finds expression only in the relationship in which humans stand in front of each other's (Marx, 1932, p. 32). This overlaps with another assertion for Marx where he considers humans as social beings by nature, but this aspect of alienation strips them of this quality. Hence, the individual is a social being, and the manifestations of their life—even if they do not appear in the direct form of the popular manifestations of life that are realized in association with others—are an expression of social life and a confirmation of it (Marx, 1932, p. 45).

In conclusion, the four aforementioned forms of alienation—from which the worker suffers—are interconnected, and the occurrence of one of them is a condition for the other. Furthermore, these forms serve as indicators that reflect, in one way or another, the conditions and suffering of workers under the capitalist system.

Factors of Alienation:

Marx did not limit himself to presenting the aforementioned manifestations of alienation. Rather, he analyzed the factors that drive workers to alienation, attributing this alienation to three factors:

A. Private Property:

Private property² exists in a capitalist economic system based on exploitation and considers the basis of this system. It plays a role in eliminating everything human in the worker's life and in the dominance of the material. Marx points out that private property has made us so stupid and one-sided that a thing is ours only when we own it—when it exists for us as capital, or when we directly own it, or eat it, drink it, wear it, live in it; in short, when we use it (Marx, 1932, p. 103) 45). In addition to playing an important role in the alienation of workers, it is the material, tangible expression of alienated human life (Marx, 1947, p. 97).

On the other hand, private property, with its two components: labor and capital, contributes to the alienation of the workers and the deepening of the adverse conditions

² Private property is an economic term that refers to all the private property owned by an individual, such as his car, farm, etc. (Encyclopedia of Business Foundation for Publishing and Distribution, 1996, p. 120). It overlaps in meaning with personal property, but the essential difference between them is exploitation and operation. In private property, the car or farm is exploited and operated to serve the owner, while this does not occur in personal property.

they suffers. The path through which its two components pass illustrates the character of private property which is expressed by labor, by capital, and by the relationship between these two. Also, the movement through which these components must pass is as follow.

First, the unity of the two throughout a mediator or not and since capital and labor are at first still united. Then, although they become separate and alienated, each develops and impels the others under positive conditions.

Second, the two are in opposition and mutually exclude each other. The workers know the capitalist as the negation of their own existence, and vice versa as each attempts to deprive the other of its existence.

Third, each is in contradiction with itself (Marx, 1932, p. 39).

Note that private property is not only a factor causing alienation but also a result of it, as it is represented by the product of labor alienated from the worker. Furthermore, the relationship between alienation and private property is one of reciprocal influence, as private property leads to alienation and is then embodied in the form of the alienated product produced by the worker (Marx, 1974, p. 78).

Thus, private property, through its various means, works to spread an atmosphere of alienation among workers and intensify their harsh conditions. This is the most influential factor in causing alienation. Another factor follows after this: the political economy.

B. Political Economy:

The second factor causing alienation, political economy³, emerges in Marx's analysis and takes on a special meaning different from its contemporary scientific meaning. Marx considers it the science of wealth, and at the same time the science of denial, desire, and saving. It reaches the point where man no longer needs fresh air or physical exercise (Marx, 1932, p. 50-51). Political economy has its own tools and methods to exploit workers. These tools and methods are embodied in the following:

³ This term consists of two parts: economics and politics. It refers to issues related to both disciplines. Economics was the traditional name for economics, while the term "political" referred to its relationship to state activity and politics in general (Salloum, 1992, p. 348). Furthermore, it discusses issues related to the state's wealth without excluding political considerations from this discussion (Al-Kayali, 1990, p. 238).

- 1-Reducing the worker's needs to the lowest and most deficient level of survival.
- 2-Considering this level of survival as the primary criterion for their life. Hence, any luxury on the part of the worker is blameworthy, and any behavior that exceeds the needs determined by this standard is considered a luxury (Marx, 1974, p. 109).

In addition, the political economy is based on creating pseudo-needs and disseminating its own ideology: the ideology of mortification and asceticism. It fosters a climate of asceticism among workers, reduces their needs to the greatest possible extent, and disseminates idealistic slogans that emphasize asceticism and frugality. The best worker, for example, is the most ascetic and devout. Marx explains that bluntly as the pseudo-industrial science is at the same time the science of asceticism; its ideal is the ascetic miser and usurer, the ascetic slave and producer. Its moral ideal is the worker who takes a portion of their wages to the savings bank. Thus, political economy—despite its worldly, sensual appearance—is a truly moral science, the most moral of all sciences. Self-denial, the denial of life and all human needs, is its fundamental principle. The less you eat, drink, and read; the less you frequent the theater, the dance hall, and the cafeteria; the less you think, love, theorize, sing, paint, duel, etc.; the more you accumulate—the greater your treasure, which neither moth nor dust can devour—the greater your capital. The less you exist, the greater your possessions; the less you express your life, the greater your life, and your alienated existence increases. Everything that the political economist takes from you in human life, they give you in return in money and wealth. Everything you cannot do, your money does (Marx, 1974, p. 110).

Thus, political economy contributes to the alienation of workers by completing the task of the worker who preceded it and paving the way for another worker to do their own work, intensifying the workers' problems and harsh conditions and increasing their alienation, which is the division of labor.

C. Division of Labor:

Marx deems this factor a complement to the previous factors in achieving workers' alienation and creating the harsh conditions in which they live. Under the conditions of the division of labor, the worker suffers from an inability to determine their own direction, on the one hand, and from dependence on the capitalist (Marx, 1974, p. 16). However, the conditions of workers are linked to the degree of division of labor. For

example, under conditions of severe division of labor the workers degenerate to the point where they become a productive machine and fall to its level, losing their humanity, becoming worthless and insignificant. Owing to the harsh conditions of the division of labor, each performing repetitive and monotonous work, producing little output on the one hand, but this leads to the accumulation of capital and its concentration in the hands of employers and capitalists on the other hand. Furthermore, the worker is also subject to market fluctuations, changes in societal conditions, and the whims of the wealthy and capitalists (Marx, 1974, p. 18).

Unlike the French sociologist Émile Durkheim, who believed that the division of labor plays an important function in achieving solidarity among members of society, Marx viewed it as a means of alienating the workers. It devalue them, and deepen their dependence on the capitalist, on the one hand, and it can be a means of entrenching the capitalists' exploitation of the workers and increasing their profits and capital, on the other hand. Despite the fact that it provides significant benefits to society through increased wealth and improved economic conditions, it impoverishes the workers and devalues them to the point of being reduced to a machine. While work brings the accumulation of capital and prosperity in society, it makes the workers more dependent on the capitalist, drives them to competition with new intensity, and throws them into the wheel of overproduction and the recession that accompanies it (Marx, 1932, p. 6).

Based on the above, Marx noted the interconnectedness of the factors causing alienation. The whole of political economy agrees that the division of labor and the wealth of production and the division of labor and the accumulation of capital are in a reciprocal relationship. It also agrees that only liberated private property can produce the most extensive and far-reaching division of labor (Marx, 1974, p. 122).

Overcoming Alienation:

Marx presents a vision of overcoming alienation that is fundamentally linked to private property. He considers liberation from private property a prerequisite for overcoming alienation (Marx, 1974, p. 97). However, liberation from private property and overcoming alienation are also linked to the liberation of workers, to changing the existing capitalist economic system, and to the transition to a communist system as the embodiment of abolished private property. Furthermore, communism is the foundation

for the worker's liberation from alienation and the yoke of capitalist exploitation, on the one hand, and a fundamental pillar of a humane and free society, on the other. Marx believed that there are three forms of communism: *crude*, *incomplete*, and *mature*. Private property is abolished in all three of these forms, but the degree of abolition varies from one form to another.

In *crude communism*, private property is not abolished, but rather the idea of collective private property emerges, eliminating everything that is not collectively owned, such as talents, and promoting interest in the material aspect. For instance, it is clearly evident in the women's commune, which makes women collective property (Marx, 1974, p. 94). As for *incomplete communism*, it remains influenced by private property and in it the alienation of the human self is transcended but it remains captive to need; it has grasped its concept, but not its essence (Marx, 1974, p. 96). Private property and alienation are transcended in the third form, *mature communism*, where humanity prevails and the conflict between people, on the one hand, and between them and nature, on the other, is eliminated. It is the positive transcendence of private property, or human self-alienation. This communism—as a fully developed nature—equals humanity as it is the true solution to the conflict between human and nature and between human themselves (Marx, 1974, p. 96).

Critical Evaluation:

Since analysis alone is insufficient, criticism must be applied, given its key role in expanding the epistemological vision of the study and looking beyond the given. This section will also examine the results of this study and offer some critical analysis about Marx's view of alienation.

Firstly, Marx made numerous contributions to the fields of philosophy and sociology. His ideas, for example, have an undeniable influence, enriching the course of philosophical and social thought with philosophical and scientific insights into the process of societal development and structure. These ideas also resonated with the lived human reality and were not confined to the theoretical realm. Thus, the tremendous impact of their contributions, which cannot be fully enumerated here, cannot be denied. In fact, Marx's writings on alienation were a resounding cry in a world that ravages and disfigures humanity. For both, alienation represents a rejection of the distortion of

humanity under capitalist systems and an attempt to pave the way for salvation and the attainment of a true humanity free from domination, exploitation, and oppression. Despite Marx's significant contributions, his works have not been without criticism, particularly those related to alienation. This criticism does not diminish the value and importance of their contributions; rather, it is an inherent feature of scholarly work. In this regard, we will suffice to discuss the criticisms directed at them by previous studies, as they must be commented upon and discussed, not merely presented.

In this context, Erickson (1999) believes that Marx's theory did not address all forms of labor and how they are formed, nor did it discuss the consequences of the scarcity of survival options. Their concepts of labor are biased against non-industrial labor. Furthermore, the four aspects of alienation identified by Marx are impossible because humans work routinely in order not to live randomly. This point, which Marx saw as present under the capitalist system, is necessary to ensure human survival, and is always present regardless of a particular time period, economic system, or political philosophy. However, what Erickson overlooked that Marx was speaking about routine in work in conjunction with the exploitation of workers in the workplace. He did not delve into the essence of human existence and their philosophy, which sees routine as an integral part of any work. Their goal is to liberate humans from the exploitation and alienation that intensify this feeling of routine.

Sayer (2011) also sees that Marx views alienation as a negative state that stands against the process of human nature's development, but this nature is not fixed and unchanging. Rather, work and alienation play a fundamental role in this process, and therefore, alienation is not negative in absolute terms. However, what is taken from Sayer is that alienation is a state of losing the bonds of connection with the surrounding and lived reality, and no matter how much one tries to reduce its negatives, it carries within it that negative character. It is not possible to reduce the pain and suffering of workers only by considering that alienation and work have a positive character and that they can achieve progress in the field of development, as Sayer points out, and this is a reduction for the pain of humans, whether they are workers or not.

Erich Fromm denotes that Marx's philosophy is a protest filled with faith in the humans' ability to liberate and realize their potential. It appears to most readers,

infected with the contagion of submission to the spirit of the age as a backward, old-fashioned philosophy with a utopian character. Nevertheless, history has corrected Marx concept of alienation, which deemed workers the most alienated and the liberation begins through their liberation. Marx was unable to predict that alienation would become the fate of most people, not only workers. The current study agrees with Fromm that alienation is not limited to workers. Yet, their condemnation of any thought that contradicts Marx's view that it is subservient to reality is an excessive generalization and an attempt to mummify Marxist thought and make it more of a ritual than an epistemological and philosophical thought that is open to criticism.

Daojin and Juan (2015) asserted that the scope of vision in their theory remains confined to the arena of capitalist products which ignores alienation in the social and political context, the alienation of the human spirit, and other forms of alienation in life. We agree with this critique in many points, but Marx's critique of capitalism is, at its core, a critique of the policies of capitalist society, and that the alienation of workers is, at its core, social alienation.

Considering the above, the study addresses some points that Marx overlooked or that were pitfalls in his study of the concept of alienation. Marx limited the study of alienation to workers which cannot reflect the situation of all classes of society and cannot serve as a standard for them at all. This limitation constitutes a kind of fragmentation of the concept of alienation. In their presentation of the alienation of workers, there is an implicit assumption that all workers are oppressed, all good, and all violated. Additionally, this narrows the image of the worker, as they believes that alienation will disappear with the disappearance of the causes that led to it. This ignores the existential alienation that arises with humans from the beginning of life until its end, and which is manifested in human questions about existence, creation, the universe, and life. Alienation cannot end at a specific point or with the disappearance of specific causes; because it is an existential phenomenon that continues with the individual until the end of their life, and not merely a social phenomenon. As for the second point, which is that they attribute all evils to capitalism reduces the concept of the human being and considers people as passive recipients of control outside of them. Consequently, this ignores the differences between people and considers them similar beings who are subject to and affected, but do not affect.

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